

Kirkpatrick's Levels of Evaluation
"Competencies for Leadership in Higher Education" Workshop
Westwood University Center for Innovation in Higher Education

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Introduction

This report presents an analysis of evaluation data gathered for the "Competencies for Leadership in Higher Education" workshop conducted by the Center for Innovation in Higher Education (CIHE) at Westwood University (WU). The workshop is a 5-day leadership development program for select faculty members from the Middle East countries: Egypt, Oman, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates. This is the first time the workshop is offered and WU's provost has taken special interest in the evaluation process; design, develop and conduct a robust evaluation. So, the stakes are high because future contacts with international partners depend on the workshop's effectiveness. The analysis is organized using Kirkpatrick's evaluation framework (Kirkpatrick & Kirkpatrick, 2006). The data comes from the workshop evaluation survey (Level 1) conducted at the end of the fifth day and employer behavioral observations conducted 60 days post-workshop (Level 3).

Level 1 Evaluation Analysis: Reaction

Level 1 evaluates the participants' reactions to the training in terms of relevance, engagement, satisfaction, and the entire experience. The data was collected through a survey administered at the close of the final workshop day. The survey included 7 items measured using a 5-point standard agreement scale: Strongly Agree, Agree, Neutral, Disagree, and Strongly Disagree. 31 responses were collected. The raw response count for each item is presented in Table 1 and visualized in Figure 1. The survey also included 3 open-ended questions.

Satisfaction Trend

To analyze the overall satisfaction trend, the survey data are clustered in complementary bins as shown in Table 1. Both groupings show that the 66% of the participants are satisfied. However, it is worth looking deeply to reveal any hidden trends.

Cluster 1: The survey results in this cluster are divided into three categories:

1. Towards Agree (SA + A)
2. Neutral (N)
3. Towards Disagree (D + SD).

This grouping is slightly misleading because it suggests that overall 1 in 5 responses tend towards disagreement, while 4 in 5 responses are moving towards agreement. A data-driven approach in this case will conclude that the Level 1 evaluation shows the workshop training was a success.

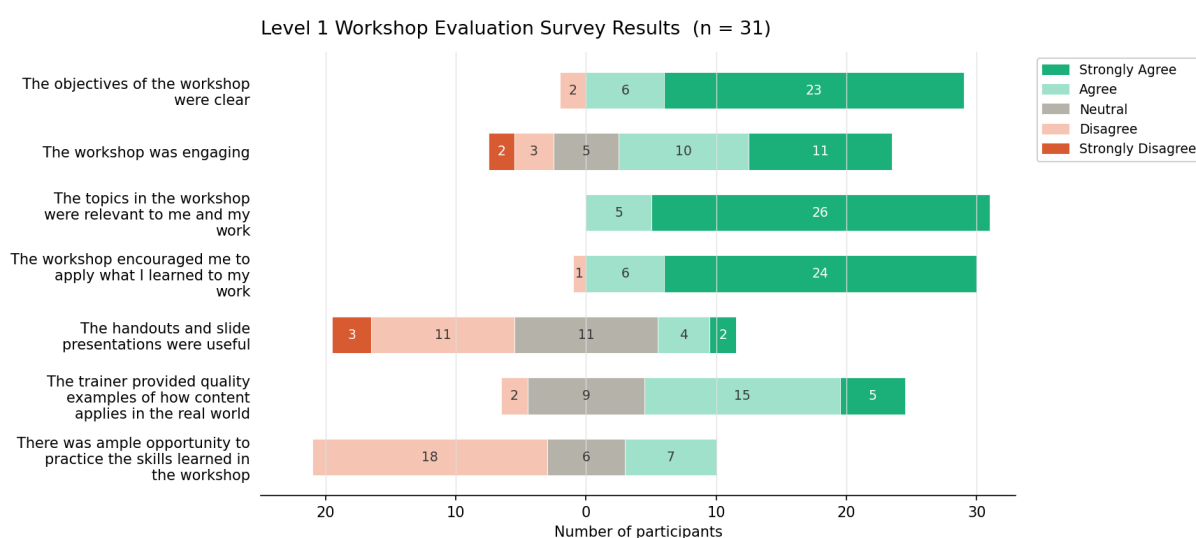


Figure 1
Level 1 quantitative survey results.

Cluster 2: In this clustering, the survey results are divided into two categories:

1. Optimistic group (SA + A)
2. Not-So-Optimistic group (N + D + SD)

This is a data-informed approach because it reflects the high-stakes context of this evaluation and this is the first time CIHE has offered this workshop; there are no prior benchmarks or historical data. The future international contracts depend on the program's demonstrated

effectiveness, and the evaluation must consequently apply a high standard of success. Therefore, in this context, a neutral response is not a positive outcome and clearly indicates that the workshop did not produce a clearly positive impression in that area. In this cluster, 1 in 3 participants tend towards disagreement, which is 10 out of 30 participants who were not satisfied with the training.

Table 1
Level 1 Workshop Evaluation Survey Results

Survey Item	SA + A	N	D + SD	SA + A	N + D + SD
1. The objectives of the workshop were clear	95%	0	5%	95%	5%
2. The workshop was engaging	68%	15%	17%	68	32%
3. The topics in the workshop were relevant to me and my work	100%	0%	0%	100%	0%
4. The workshop encouraged me to apply what I learned to my work	96%	0%	4%	96%	4%
5. The handouts and slide presentations were useful	20%	34%	46%	20%	80%
6. The trainer provided quality examples of how content applies in the real world	64%	29%	7%	64%	36%
7. There was ample opportunity to practice the skills learned in the workshop	24%	18%	58%	24%	76%
Overall average	66%	14%	20%	66%	34%

Note. SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; N = Neutral; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree.

A careful examination of the data under this clustering criterion reveals 3 distinct trends across the seven survey items. These are highlighted using a coloring scheme in Table 2. These 3 trends also outline the instructional designer/trainer's perspective.

Trend 1: Systematic Strengths

Items 1, 3, and 4 (highlighted in blue) stand out as clear and decisive strengths of the workshop. The results overwhelmingly lean towards agreement, 95%, 100%, and 96%, respectively, and are dominated by Strongly Agree with 74%, 84%, and 77%, respectively. There was a small disagreement in Items 1 and 4 (2 and 1 participants, respectively), and these can be considered outliers for this trend. This indicates that the objectives of the workshop were clear, the topics were relevant, and the workshop was successful in encouraging the participants to apply the learnings to their work.

Table 2
Level 1 Workshop Evaluation Survey Results

Survey Item	SA	A	N	D	SD
1. The objectives of the workshop were clear	23	6	0	2	0
2. The workshop was engaging	11	10	5	3	2
3. The topics in the workshop were relevant to me and my work	26	5	0	0	0
4. The workshop encouraged me to apply what I learned to my work	24	6	0	1	0
5. The handouts and slide presentations were useful	2	4	11	11	3
6. The trainer provided quality examples of how content applies in the real world	5	15	9	2	0
7. There was ample opportunity to practice the skills learned in the workshop	0	7	6	18	0

Note. SA = Strongly Agree; A = Agree; N = Neutral; D = Disagree; SD = Strongly Disagree.

Instructional Designer/Trainer Perspective: The results directly point to the great quality of the front-end workshop design. They highlight the needs analysis conducted before the workshop development to identify the measurable learning objectives was a success; the 100% relevance rating in Item 3 confirms it and is supported by 95% of the participants who leaned towards agreement that the workshop objectives were clear. The near-perfect score, with only one disagreement, on Item 4 suggests that the facilitators communicated the "so-what" of each session effectively which helped participants see the connection between workshop content and real-world leadership challenges. The results can be considered as a design-level win. These reflect careful evidence-based choices about what to teach and its relevance and should not be revised.

Trend 2: Mixed Opinion

Two items, Item 2 and Item 4, show a positive majority with a meaningful share of non-positive responses. This indicates partial satisfaction rather than a strong endorsement like in Trend 1. Approximately 1 in 3 participants was not fully satisfied with the workshop engagement and the quality of the examples that were provided to draw parallels between the workshop and real-world scenarios was not satisfactory. In Item 6, only 5 participants strongly agree, while 9 voted for neutral, when compared to 11 participants strongly agreeing and 5 neutrals in Item 2. Even though the overall results look the same, analyzing individual aspects reveals that even though

the workshop engagement tends towards agreement, the example quality and application to the real world are lacking. This drawback is seen in Trend 3 with large implications.

Instructional Designer/Trainer Perspective: Comparing the results of Items 3 and 4 with Items 2 and 6 indicates that participants found the workshop's relevance could be improved by providing quality examples to apply the workshop content to keep them engaged. Adult learners engage most deeply when instruction connects directly to their lived professional experience (ref) which calls for introducing a greater variety of active learning strategies with relevant real-world (Knowles et al., 2015)' examples will elevate the workshop from informative to fully immersive (Hattie & Timperley, 2007).

Trend 3: Clear Weakness

Items 5 and 7 produced decisively negative results with 80% and 76% leaning towards disagreement. One in five participants felt that the workshop's learning materials were not useful, and no participant strongly agreed that there was enough opportunity to practice the skills they gained during the workshop. Notable Item 7 is the only item that not even a single participant strongly agreed on in the entire survey, and it also recorded more than half the participants disagreeing, which is also the highest.

Instructional Designer/Trainer Perspective: Item 5: The learning materials quality failure was not an instructional design problem but a production and logistics failure that is completely preventable. Under the compressed two-month development timeline for the workshop as noted in the case, materials (slides and handouts) were likely finalized without multiple revisions. Therefore, the participants struggles to make full use of the materials. CIHE must rethink its strategy to establish a formal quality assurance protocol for all instructional materials before delivery. A structured material review for accuracy, formatting, consistency, and professional standards before they reach the participants is very vital. Given that this is the first time the workshop is offered and the timeline, this failure is not a surprise and needs immediate revision.

Item 7: The lack of practice opportunity is the most consequential instructional design finding in Level 1 data, and its implications extend directly to transfer of learning. This is a more

serious failure when compared to Item 4. In the current structure, the workshop prioritizes content delivery over skill development and application. This is a well-documented design pattern that research identifies as insufficient for developing behavioral competencies (Baldwin & Ford, 1988). Participants cannot be expected to transfer a skill to the workplace that they have never had the opportunity to rehearse in a structured, feedback-rich environment (Hattie & Timperley, 2007). Therefore, the workshop delivery must be fundamentally rebalanced to promote dedicated practice time within each day's schedule as they gain necessary skills.

Level 2 Evaluation Analysis: Learning

Level 2 evaluation assesses which knowledge, skills, or attitudes changed as a result of the training. The workshop evaluation design did not include a formal Level 2 instrument. This is a significant gap in the evaluation methodology, limiting the ability to draw insights into learning outcomes. Therefore, in the absence of Level 2 data, inferences must be drawn from qualitative comments in the Level 1 survey.

A consistent pattern emerges from the Level 1 qualitative responses that the participants generally reported understanding the concepts presented, but expressed uncertainty about their ability to apply that understanding in practice. The comments include, "I felt like I was learning when I was there, and I think I understand all the concepts, but I don't feel like I have everything I need to really start using the skills in the workplace," and "I understand what was taught, but I am not sure that I will be able to apply what I learned very easily when I get to work." These comments suggest that declarative knowledge acquisition of understanding the concepts may have been reasonably successful but the procedural knowledge of knowing how to do something in a context remained underdeveloped. This trend is also seen in the survey results for Items 6 and 7 from Level 1 data. Also, one participant offered a positive learning specific to building positive relations suggests that learning outcomes were more achieved when practice was embedded in the instruction: "I enjoyed the practice that we had when we were working with the communication skills. This helped me to think more about my own communication strategies."

Instructional Designer/Trainer Perspective

A significant instructional design concern at Level 2 is the absence of formal learning assessment. Effective Level 2 evaluation design is assessed through instruments such as knowledge checks, skill demonstrations, or competency self-assessments administered before and after instruction. These assessments are distinct from Level 1 reaction surveys. Due to the lack of such assessment instruments, the organization cannot confidently report the workshop outcomes to the Provost.

Level 3 Evaluation Analysis: Behavior

Level 3 evaluation asks the hardest post-training questions to examine the extent to which the learning actually transferred to their job. To assess the behavioral change and transfer of learning, the participants' managers conducted an evaluation 60 days after the training. They spent a whole week observing their employees as they conduct their work. 17 out of 30 participants were observed, yielding a 57% response rate. Table 3 presents computed mean scores for all competencies and domain-level overall ratings, while the raw scores for Self-Leadership and Building Positive Relationships, and for Innovation and Leadership and Managing Others are visualized in Figure 2 and Figure 4 3, respectively.

There are several important limitations to be addressed before the insights from Level 3 data are presented. 13 (43%) participants have no behavioral observational data reported, and there is no information on whether this missing data is systematically biased, i.e., low performing participants were less likely to be observed. The dataset also acknowledges the absence of pre-training baseline data though the participants were selected by their supervisors as "rising stars" which suggests some baseline leadership strengths implicitly. For complex leadership competencies that require continuous practice and organizational support, a 60-day follow-up timeline is relatively short for behavioral change to fully emerge. Finally, the rating consistency across four countries with different institutional cultures raises the question of reliability.

The Level 3 data reveal a consistent pattern across all four competency domains with average scores less than 3, i.e., slightly less than the average rating. Under this baseline,

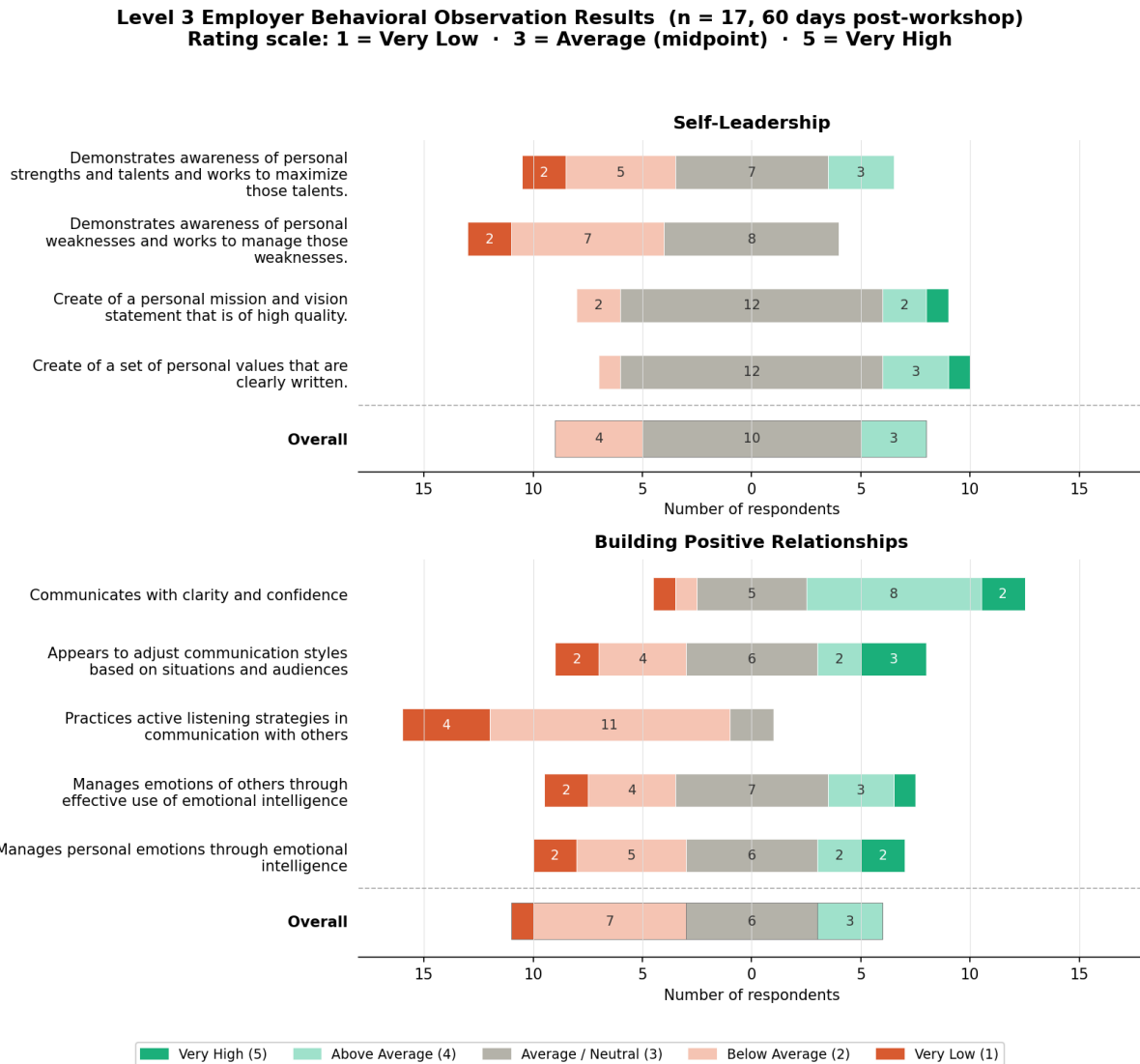


Figure 2
Self-Leadership and Building Positive Relationships

Level 3 Employer Behavioral Observation Results (n = 17, 60 days post-workshop)
Rating scale: 1 = Very Low · 3 = Average (midpoint) · 5 = Very High

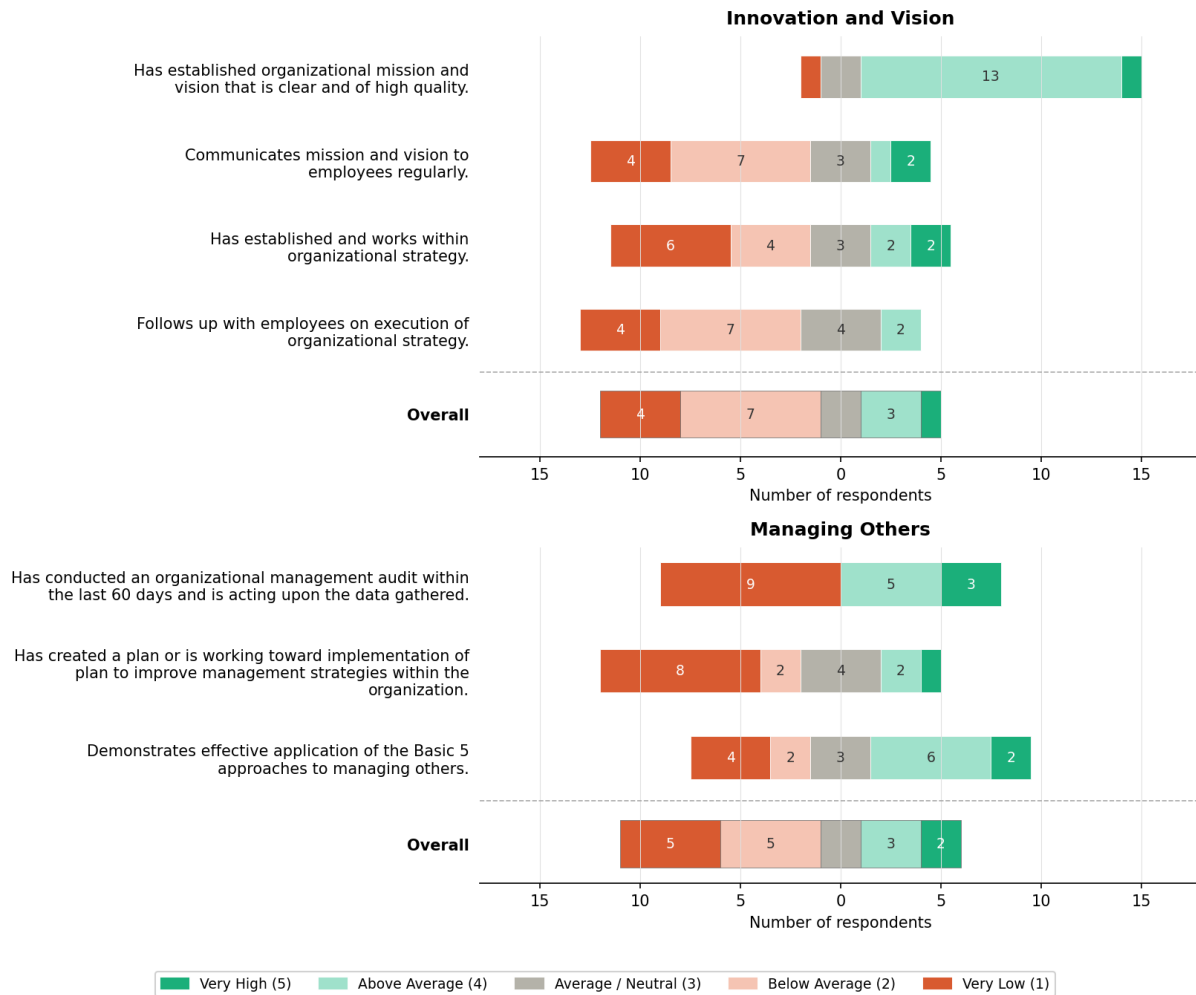


Figure 3
Innovation & Vision and Managing Others

Table 3*Level 3 Employer Behavioral Observation Results (n = 17, 60 Days Post-Workshop)*

Domain	Competency	Mean (1–5)
Self-Leadership	Demonstrates awareness of personal strengths and talents and works to maximize those talents.	2.65
	Demonstrates awareness of personal weaknesses and works to manage those weaknesses.	2.35
	Creates a personal mission and vision statement of high quality.	3.11
	Creates a set of personal values that are clearly written.	3.24
	<i>Domain Overall</i>	<i>2.94</i>
Building Positive Relationships	Communicates with clarity and confidence.	3.53
	Appears to adjust communication styles based on situations and audiences.	3.00
	Practices active listening strategies in communication with others.	1.88
	Manages emotions of others through effective use of emotional intelligence.	2.82
	Manages personal emotions through emotional intelligence.	2.82
	<i>Domain Overall</i>	<i>2.65</i>
Innovation and Vision	Has established organizational mission and vision that is clear and of high quality.	3.76
	Communicates mission and vision to employees regularly.	2.41
	Has established and works within organizational strategy.	2.41
	Follows up with employees on execution of organizational strategy.	2.24
	<i>Domain Overall</i>	<i>2.41</i>
Managing Others	Has conducted an organizational management audit within the last 60 days and is acting upon the data gathered.	2.59
	Has created a plan or is working toward implementation of plan to improve management strategies within the organization.	2.18
	Demonstrates effective application of the Basic 5 approaches to managing others.	3.00
	<i>Domain Overall</i>	<i>2.53</i>

Note. Scale: 1 = Very Low; 2 = Below Average; 3 = Average; 4 = Above Average; 5 = Very High. Domain Overall means reflect supervisor overall domain ratings, not computed averages of sub-competencies.

competencies involving the creation of written documents or artifacts showed the strongest performance compared to competencies requiring behavioral implementation and interpersonal

application.

In the **Self-Leadership domain (overall M = 2.94)**, the mission/vision statement quality and personal values statement showed the strongest performance with means of 3.11 and 3.24, respectively. These two artifacts were practiced during the workshop. However, the awareness of personal strengths and weaknesses fell below the midpoint, with a mean of 2.65 and 2.35, respectively. Together these two suggest that the 17 participants have strong artifacts at hand but are yet to actively leverage them.

The **Building Positive Relationships domain (overall M = 2.65)** contained both the highest and lowest individual competency scores in the entire dataset. Communication clarity and confidence had the majority of the observations at "above average" with a mean of 3.53 (highest overall) which suggests that the communication content transferred relatively well. In sharp contrast, active listening received the lowest mean score in the entire dataset at 1.88 with 15 of 17 supervisors rating the participants at "very low" (4 supervisors) or "below average" (11 supervisors). Given that active listening is a major foundation for effective communication, a question of data validity arises here because adjusting communication styles based on situations and audiences scored a mean of 3 requires the participants to have listened to the audiences before they could adjust their communication style. To add more weightage to this claim, the use of emotional intelligence to manage emotions of themselves and others scored a mean of 2.82.

The **Innovation and Vision domain (overall M = 2.41)** reveals perhaps the most analytically interesting pattern with an overall average of 2.41. The quality of established organizational mission and vision scored the highest of any competency in the dataset (M = 3.76), with 14 of 17 supervisors rating participants either "above average" (13) or "very good" (1). However, the three competencies related to operationalizing that vision: communicating it to employees (M = 2.41), working within organizational strategy (M = 2.41), and following up on strategy execution (M = 2.24), all scored substantially lower. This divergence suggests that participants learned to create vision documents but did not develop the leadership behaviors required to bring those documents to life in their organizations.

The **Managing Others domain (overall M = 2.53)** produced the most polarized findings. The organizational management audit competency showed unusual distribution, with 9 supervisors rating "very low" and 8 rating "above average"(5) or "very high" (3); no rating for "low" or "average". These ratings likely reflects differences in the institutional contexts of participants and suggests some home institutions may have organizational conditions that support conducting a management audit, while others may not. Creating improvement plans was predominantly weak with a mean of 2.18 where 8 out of 17 rated "very low".

Recommendations

Recommendation 1: Implement Pre-Workshop Quality Assurance and Logistics Protocols

The Level 1 data identified the quality of instructional materials as a critical failure and a 45-minute tech setup problem on Day 1. These are entirely preventable issues, especially the technology setup. Participants should obtain login access and confirm the setup before they travel, so any issues can be resolved before they arrive at WU. CIHE should implement a mandatory final review process for all instructional materials after a few revisions.

Recommendation 2: Significantly Increase Embedded Practice Opportunities

The most consistent finding across all three levels is the lack of ample practice time to apply the workshop learning. Insights from Level 3 data suggest that the most practiced competencies, such as mission/vision creation, were transferred effectively. However, the least practiced competencies such as active listening and strategy execution showed the weakest outcomes.

Recommendation 3: Add a Formal Level 2 Assessment Instrument

A formal Level 2 assessment is missing in the workshop design which needs to be corrected for the next iteration. CIHE must develop and administer a pre/post competency assessments in each of the four domains. These are administered on the morning of Day 1 and the afternoon of Day 5 to get a baseline data and measure gains within the workshop.

Recommendation 4: Redesign for Transfer: Add Structured Application Planning and Post-Workshop Support

The learning transfer gap stands out from Level 1 comments and Level 3 data because participants understood the concepts well during the course of the workshop but when they returned to their home institutions were uncertain how to apply them. Also, the current informal contact exchange is insufficient as one participant explicitly commented: "Maybe give us a way to stay connected with our coaches in a formal manner. I would love to have the mentoring continue after the workshop." CIHE should establish a formal post-workshop support structure to conduct a timely follow-up session, say 30, 60, 90, and 120 days, led by coaches. Participants can be grouped by institutions for efficient coordination.

Recommendation 5: Improve Follow-Up Observation Process and Coverage

The lack of sufficient Level 3 data leaves 13 participants without behavioral data. With 57% completion rate, it is challenging to draw conclusive insights. CIHE should formalize its post-workshop data collection as an absolute requirement in the agreement with the institutions.

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